

Police is toying with the idea of making Khali its brand ambassador.

But they will have to wait. Currently, Khali is shooting a song for a Tamil film near Madurai. He will then return to Mumbai to shoot three days for a children's film, with Tanushree Dutta and Sahil Khan, called *Rama: The Saviour* before heading home. In the US, a big release awaits him—a Steve Carell movie, *Get Smart*, which also stars a wrestling predecessor, Dwayne 'The Rock' Johnson.

That he is not a particularly talented wrestler goes without saying. To

Bhullar, retired director-general of Punjab Police, first learnt about "an eight-foot tall wonder" from the local media. As the inspector-general of Punjab Armed Police, Bhullar was known for his passion for recruiting fresh blood into the force. He tracked down Rana and offered him a job as constable in the Punjab Police. Rana was reluctant, but agreed when Bhullar offered to recruit his younger brother as well. "He was tall, awkwardly so, with a scrawny build, and appeared to be under-nourished," recalls Bhullar. He was first tried out in

Wrestling and in 2001, he was signed by New Japan Pro Wrestling, the largest professional wrestling company in Asia. His stage name? Giant Singh.

But his real success came in January 2006 when he signed a contract for WWE, which registered his new name, The Great Khali. They gave him 12 signature moves that are now part of most urban Indian children's vocabulary—many of whom are glued to Ten Sports' telecasts of WWE—and a fearsome back story to excite bloodthirsty Middle America. But instant fame and stardom—a salary of \$200,000

FROM RANA TO KHALI: HIMACHAL LABOURER TO PUNJABI WARRIOR

The Great Khali makes \$200,000 a year as an employee at WWE. It is a three-year contract, beginning 2006.



He weighs 190 kg and is 7 foot 3 inches tall.

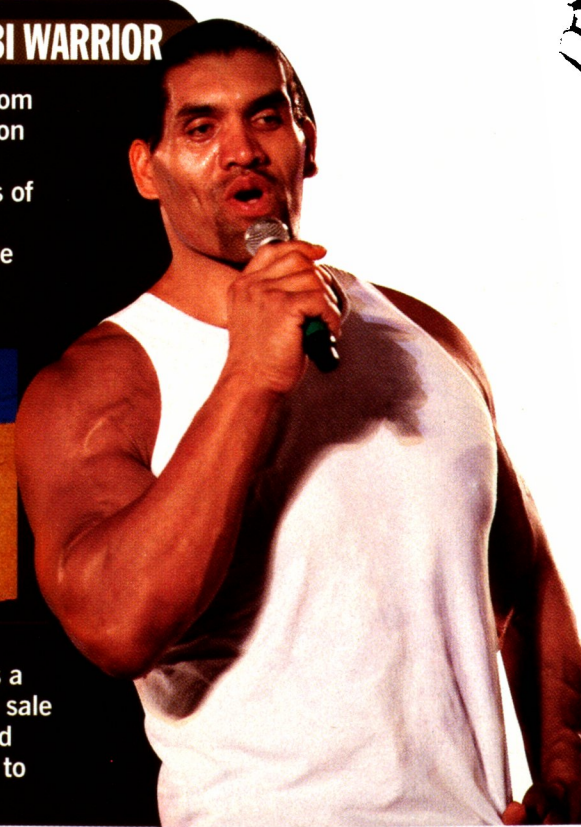
He gets between \$0.5 million to \$2 million per film, a percentage of which also goes to WWE.



Check out his transformation from gentle giant to Punjabi warrior on the WWE site: This enormous monster has walked the jungles of India unafraid of pythons and wrestled white Bengal tigers. He stared into the abyss and the earth trembled at his gaze.



The Great Khali is a registered trademark of WWE and he gets a percentage of revenue from the sale of products in his name. It could range from ringtones for \$2.49 to action figures for \$10.



ANINDITO MUKHERJEE

gauntlets thrown at him by domestic stars such as Commonwealth Games gold medalist Palwinder Singh Cheema or freestyle champion Parminder Dhoomchheri, he has only made humble comments: "I am not visiting my country to fight and prove my wrestling credentials." Quite apart from the sniggers about WWE, his rise has been a struggle against circumstances. A school dropout, Khali started working as a day-jobber, evoking ridicule for his physique, which forced him to escape to Shimla where he worked as a porter, truck-loader and even security guard. It was in 1993 when Mehal Singh

basketball but his reflexes were found to be slow. He then tried his hand at discus and showed promise but soon developed back pain. He shifted to body-building and won a title at the national level. "He was very passionate and hard working," adds Bhullar. But with weak thigh and calf muscles, Bhullar realised Khali wouldn't go far in body-building. He was struck by the idea of letting him try his luck with the WWE in the US, and sent him there in 1996. A year-and-a-half of training at San Francisco honed Khali's skills and started him off in the pro-wrestling circuit. His first break was with the All Pro

(Rs 85 lakh) a year from WWE plus \$0.5 million to \$2 million per Hollywood film—have not altered his modest lifestyle. Rana and his wife, Harminder, live in a twin bedroom apartment at McDonough, a small town near Hick Central, Atlanta, Georgia.

As of now, with his hands full of celebrity invites and advertisement offers, he has a dream: to set up a training academy to produce "two or three Khalis before I retire". Till then, he's quite happy to play up to the American stereotype of the barbaric Indian. He may be regarded as a circus exhibit, but he's going to end up a very rich one. ■